

The M FACTOR

In about 100 constituencies where the Muslim vote is decisive, the N-deal may generate more debate than inflation or terrorism

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When in desperation, put on your skull cap. The nuclear deal hitherto debated away from its communal implications, has been gaining the good ol' Muslim angle. Though the deal is yet to be signed, community organisations and politicians are revving up for the occasion. It all started with CPI(M)'s senior politburo member M.K. Pandhe inserting the nuclear deal into the list of grievances of Indian Muslims and announcing that "an overwhelming majority of the Muslim masses" opposed it. He urged Samajwadi Party (SP) president Mulayam Singh Yadav not to alienate them by supporting it. Though the Left party quickly distanced itself from his comments, the debate gained momentum as political parties jumped to the conclusion that the deal with the "Satan" can be a big ticket item in around 100 constituencies, where Muslim votes are decisive.

Last week, as her arch rival Mulayam extended support to the Congress-led UPA over the nuclear deal with the US, Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Mayawati felt political tremors under her feet and followed up Pandhe's comments with vigour. She targeted Mulayam by saying that his secularism had been a *tamasha*. "Remember, it was Mulayam who had stopped Sonia Gandhi from becoming the prime minister and helped the BJP-led NDA to rule for six years. Now the Congress and SP are cosying up for the deal," she said. She firmed up her "anti-Muslim" theory by inviting influential Sunni and Shia clerics to discuss the deal's impact on the community and the problems the Muslims faced.

It was due to the efforts of former Union minister Akhilesh Das and Siraj Mehdi, both of whom had recently resigned from the Congress to join BSP, that a group of ulema and maulanas including Shia cleric Maulana Kalbe Sadiq, Maulana Khalid Rasheed Fringi Mahali and Maulana Fazl-ur-Rahman, many of whom were with 'Maulvi' Mulayam till recently, walked into her house to thank her for her bold stand

NO GOOD DEAL: Muslims are being told that the deal is bad for them

